Practical Livelock Analysis in Parameterized Unidirectional Rings

Aly Farahat

Abstract

We develop a framework for livelock analysis in parameterized unidirectional rings. Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir established that livelock detection for such rings is Σ_1^0-complete via reduction from the periodic domino problem, using a torus characterization. We observe that lifting the analysis to the space of transition–witness pairs reveals finite-automaton structure not visible in the torus model.

We construct a *product transition graph* $G_\times(T)$ (at most $|T|^2$ nodes) whose cycles capture the pairwise equivariant structure underlying all livelocks. The maximal witness-closed subgraph $G^*(T)$ is computable in polynomial time. When $G^*(T) = \emptyset$, the protocol is provably livelock-free for all ring sizes. When $G^*(T) \neq \emptyset$, a backtracking search over simple cycles detects livelocks with period at most $|T|^2$.

We prove a *bijection proposition*: in any closing backward chain, the backward maps are cyclic bijections on product graph nodes, forcing simple cycles to backward-propagate to simple cycles. Combined with the necessary condition ($G^* = \emptyset$ implies livelock-freedom), this yields a three-outcome algorithm (Free, Livelock, Inconclusive) that is empirically conclusive on all 4,349 protocols tested with zero errors—including Kari's 14-tile aperiodic set converted via the K&E gadget. Despite exhaustive search across 21,000+ protocols, we have found zero instances where the Inconclusive outcome occurs on a protocol admitting a livelock. The relationship between our results and K&E's Σ_1^0-completeness remains an open question.

We extend to non-self-disabling protocols via burst closure. Python implementation at `https://github.com/cosmoparadox/mathematical-tools`.

1 Introduction

Self-stabilization [6] guarantees that a distributed system recovers from arbitrary transient faults to a legitimate configuration, regardless of the initial state. A key obstacle to self-stabilization in ring protocols is *livelock*: an infinite execution in which processes continually change state but never reach legitimacy. Determining whether a given protocol admits a livelock—for any ring size—is a fundamental parameterized verification problem.

Background. Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir [16] established that livelock detection for parameterized rings of self-disabling processes is Σ_1^0-complete and livelock-freedom verification is Π_1^0-complete, via a reduction from the periodic domino problem. Their torus characterization—the equivalence between livelocks and doubly-periodic tilings—is foundational and underlies our work. Notably, they also showed that the *synthesis* of self-stabilizing rings is decidable [16], and Farahat's equivariance framework [10] has been used to prove livelock freedom of difficult protocols such as Dijkstra's self-stabilizing token ring [13].

Our observation. Building on Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's torus characterization, we observe that lifting the analysis from individual transitions to *pairs* of transitions reveals structure that supports effective verification. A single transition cycle does not determine when equivariant closure occurs: equivariance fixes the predecessor's own and wr values (its H-walk), but not its pred values, which select specific transitions from T. Different pred assignments yield different witness cycles, which close at different periods—or not at all.

We construct a *product graph* over transition–witness pairs—at most $|T|^2$ nodes—that captures the equivariant structure. A pair commits to specific transitions at every position, including pred values, so its equivariant period is determined. Every livelock maps into the product graph (Theorem 2), producing a witness-closed subgraph. The product graph's simple cycles—of length at most $|T|^2$—identify equivariant pairs that are candidates for generating livelocks via backward propagation.

The maximal witness-closed subgraph $G^*(T)$ is computable in polynomial time. When $G^* = \emptyset$, the protocol is provably livelock-free for all ring sizes. When $G^* \neq \emptyset$, backward propagation of simple cycles through G^* serves as a sound livelock detector: any cycle whose backward chain closes in G^* generates a genuine livelock.

Our contribution.

1. *Necessary condition.* Every livelock maps into the product graph as a witness-closed subgraph (Theorem 2). Consequently, $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ implies livelock-freedom for all ring sizes, providing a polynomial-time livelock-freedom verifier.
2. *Sufficient condition.* Any simple cycle in G^* whose backward chain closes generates a genuine livelock (Theorem 4).
3. *Bijection proposition.* In any closing backward chain, the backward maps are cyclic bijections on product graph nodes, forcing simple cycles to backward-propagate to simple cycles (Proposition 8). This structural result constrains the topology of closing chains and supports the bounded witness conjecture: that every livelock admits a companion with period $\leq |T|^2$.
4. *Algorithm and empirical validation.* A two-phase algorithm—polynomial-time G^* computation followed by backtracking—is empirically conclusive on all 4,349 protocols tested with zero errors. Across 21,000+ protocols (including Kari's aperiodic tiles), no protocol admitting a livelock has ever produced the INCONCLUSIVE outcome.
5. *Extensions.* We extend to non-self-disabling protocols via burst closure (Section 8) and to $(1, 1)$-asymmetric protocols (Section 9).

The automaton–language distinction. Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's Σ_1^0-completeness uses the torus model, which operates on *strings*—walks of a given length—with an unbounded search over lengths. Our product graph operates on the *automaton* generating these strings: a finite graph of at most $|T|^2$ states. The backward map, viewed as a relation on automaton states (not string positions), must compose to the identity around the ring. The bijection proposition (Section 7) shows this forces bijectivity in closing chains. Whether this bounds the period—and thus yields decidability—remains open. The relationship between our results and K&E's Σ_1^0-completeness is unresolved: despite exhaustive search, we have found no instance where the two frameworks diverge.

2 Definitions

2.1 Unidirectional Ring Protocols

A *unidirectional ring* of size K consists of processes $P_0, P_1, \ldots, P_{K-1}$ arranged in a directed cycle. Each process P_i maintains a state variable $v_i \in \mathbb{Z}_m = \{0, 1, \ldots, m-1\}$ and can read v_i and $v_{i-1 \bmod K}$.

Definition 1 (Transition)**.** *A* transition *is a triple $t = (p, o, w) \in \mathbb{Z}_m^3$, meaning: if the predecessor's value is p and the process's own value is o, the process may write w. We call p the* pred value*, o the* own value*, and w the* written value*.*

Definition 2 (Self-disabling)**.** *A protocol T is* self-disabling *if for every transition $(p, o, w) \in T$, there is no transition $(p, w, u) \in T$ for any u. That is, after a process fires (p, o, w), it cannot fire again while the predecessor's value remains p—it must wait for an intervening state change from the predecessor. Throughout this paper, all protocols are self-disabling.*

Definition 3 (Protocol)**.** *A* protocol *is a finite self-disabling set $T \subseteq \mathbb{Z}_m^3$. A transition $(p, o, w) \in T$ is* enabled *at process P_i in configuration $(v_0, \ldots, v_{K-1})$ if $v_{i-1} = p$ and $v_i = o$.*

Definition 4 (Livelock)**.** *A* livelock *is a global periodic execution of a ring: K processes fire transitions indefinitely, returning the entire ring to the same global configuration after N steps, without ever reaching a legitimate state. As shown by Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir [16], a livelock is equivalently a valid tiling of a $K \times N$ torus, where each row is a closed walk of local transitions executed by one process, and adjacent rows satisfy the equivariance conditions (Section 3). The walk length N is the* local period*; the number of processes K is the* ring size*.*

2.2 The (l, q)-Asymmetry Model

Definition 5 ((l, q)-asymmetry)**.** *A ring protocol has (l, q)-asymmetry if there are l* distinguished *process types (each appearing exactly once) and q* other *types (each appearing one or more times, filling the remaining $K - l$ positions).*

The key cases are:

- $(0, 1)$**-asymmetry (symmetric):** All processes use the same transition set T. This is the primary focus of this paper.
- $(1, 1)$**-asymmetry:** One distinguished process P_0 uses T_0; all others use T_o. This covers Dijkstra's token ring. We extend our framework to this case in Section 9.
- **General** (l, q)**:** Stated as a future direction.

2.3 The H-Graph

Definition 6 (Shadow and witness)**.** *The* shadow *of a consecutive transition pair (t_i, t_j) with $\mathrm{own}(t_j) = \mathrm{wr}(t_i)$ is $\sigma(t_i, t_j) = (\mathrm{pred}(t_i), \mathrm{pred}(t_j))$. A transition u* witnesses *shadow (a, b) if $\mathrm{own}(u) = a$ and $\mathrm{wr}(u) = b$.*

Definition 7 (H-graph)**.** *Given a transition set L, the* H-graph *$H(L)$ is a directed graph with vertex set L and an edge $t_i \to t_j$ (an* H-edge*) whenever $\mathrm{own}(t_j) = \mathrm{wr}(t_i)$. A closed walk in $H(L)$ is a* pseudolivelock*: a sequence of local transitions that a single process could execute cyclically, if appropriately enabled by its predecessor. A pseudolivelock is necessary but not sufficient for a global livelock—it captures the local structure without guaranteeing the existence of consistent witnessing across the ring.*

3 The Product Transition Graph

3.1 Equivariance Conditions

In a livelock on a ring of size K, each process P_i executes a closed walk $W^{(i)}$ of length N in the H-graph. Adjacent processes are coupled through a *zigzag*: at each time step, the predecessor's transition both enables the current step (through its pre-fire state) and enables the next step (through its written value). This coupling is captured by four *equivariance conditions*.

For a product graph edge $(t_k, w_k) \to (t_{k+1}, w_{k+1})$, the connecting witness w_{k+1} links t_k to t_{k+1} in the zigzag $\ldots w_k \to t_k \to w_{k+1} \to t_{k+1} \to w_{k+2} \ldots$:

1. $\mathrm{own}(w_{k+1}) = \mathrm{pred}(t_k)$: w_{k+1}'s pre-fire state is the value t_k reads from its predecessor.
2. $\mathrm{wr}(w_{k+1}) = \mathrm{pred}(t_{k+1})$: w_{k+1}'s written value is what t_{k+1} reads from its predecessor.
3. $\mathrm{wr}(t_k) = \mathrm{own}(t_{k+1})$: H-edge in the t-walk.
4. $\mathrm{wr}(w_k) = \mathrm{own}(w_{k+1})$: H-edge in the w-walk.

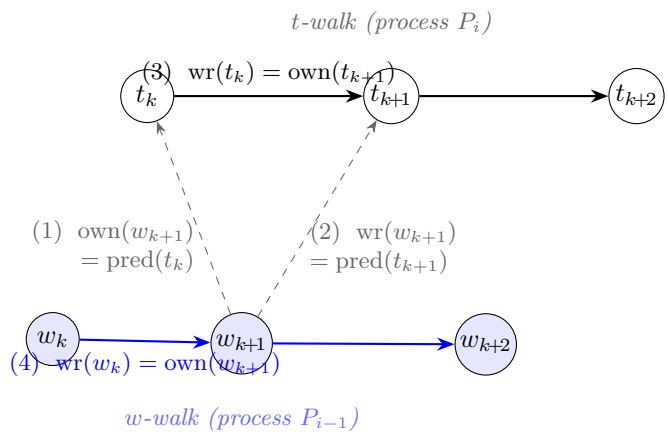

Figure 1: The zigzag coupling. The connecting witness w_{k+1} sits between t_k and t_{k+1}, linking them through its pre-fire state (condition 1) and written value (condition 2). Conditions (3) and (4) are H-edges within each walk.

Remark 1 (Emergent shadow witness)**.** *Conditions (1) and (2) together show that w_{k+1} witnesses the shadow $\sigma(t_k, t_{k+1})$:* $\mathrm{own}(w_{k+1}) = \mathrm{pred}(t_k)$ *and* $\mathrm{wr}(w_{k+1}) = \mathrm{pred}(t_{k+1})$*. The shadow witness emerges directly from the zigzag structure. Combining conditions (1) and (4) gives* $\mathrm{wr}(w_k) = \mathrm{pred}(t_k)$*, which serves as the node condition for the product graph.*

3.2 Construction

Definition 8 (Product transition graph)**.** *Given a transition set T, the* product transition graph *$G_\times(T)$ is defined as follows.*

Nodes: *Pairs $(t, w) \in T \times T$ such that* $\mathrm{wr}(w) = \mathrm{pred}(t)$*.*

Edges: $(t_k, w_k) \to (t_{k+1}, w_{k+1})$ *if all four equivariance conditions hold.*

The product graph is built once *from T and is not reconstructed during the algorithm.*

Proposition 1 (Size)**.** *$G_\times(T)$ has at most $|T|^2$ nodes and at most $|T|^4$ edges.*

3.3 Backward Propagation

A cycle in $G_\times(T)$ encodes the coupling between two adjacent processes. In a ring, this coupling extends to all K processes through *backward propagation*: the w-walk of one coupling becomes the t-walk of the predecessor's coupling. The product graph captures this structure internally: if an arc has w-pair (w_1, w_2), the predecessor coupling requires an arc with t-pair (w_1, w_2)—which is another arc in the *same* product graph.

This observation motivates the three pruning operations in the algorithm.

4 Livelock Analysis via the Product Graph

We develop the analysis through three subsections: the product graph's role in capturing equivariant walks, the witness-closed property, and the necessary/sufficient conditions for livelocks.

4.1 The Product Graph Captures Pairwise Equivariant Walks

By Definition 8, a cycle in an equivariance graph $G_\times(S)$ is precisely a pair of closed walks—the t-walk and the w-walk—coupled by the four equivariance conditions at every step. A cycle of length N in $G_\times(S)$ returns to its starting node (t_0, w_0), so both the t-walk and the w-walk close with the same length N by the graph structure.

Conversely, any pair of equivariant closed walks of the same length N over S defines a cycle of length N in $G_\times(S)$. The product graph is a faithful representation of pairwise equivariant closed walks—it imposes no conditions beyond equivariance.

Remark 2 (Self-disabling and the zigzag)**.** *The product graph's faithfulness depends critically on self-disabling. In a self-disabling protocol, a process cannot fire again until its predecessor changes state. The coupling between adjacent processes is therefore one-to-one: each step of the t-walk corresponds to exactly one connecting witness in the w-walk, producing the zigzag $\ldots w_k \to t_k \to w_{k+1} \to t_{k+1} \to \ldots$ Without self-disabling, a process could fire multiple times between consecutive predecessor firings, the coupling would no longer be one-to-one, and the product graph would not faithfully capture the equivariant structure.*

This one-to-one coupling is the token propagation discipline identified by Farahat and Ebnenasir [11]: in a self-disabling ring, an enabled process fires, disables itself, and enables its successor—propagating the token forward without duplication or destruction. The zigzag is the algebraic expression of this discipline.

The use of pairs is not incidental, and the reason is subtle. Given a closed t-cycle of period N, equivariance determines the predecessor's own and wr values at every position: the predecessor's H-walk is forced and closes automatically. However, the predecessor's pred values—which select which specific *transitions* from T realize the H-walk—are not determined by the t-cycle alone. In a non-deterministic protocol, multiple transitions may share the same (own, wr) but have different pred values. Different pred assignments yield different transition walks, which may close at different periods or not at all (see Section 6, Trial 56). This is the period determination problem: the t-cycle determines the predecessor's H-walk (a sequence of own / wr values), but not its transition walk (a sequence of specific transitions from T).

The product graph resolves this by committing to specific transitions at every position—including their pred values. A cycle in the product graph returns to the *same node* (t_0, w_0), guaranteeing that the transition walk closes exactly, not just the H-walk. Pairs of transitions are the minimal unit that resolves the period: once a transition cycle is paired with a specific witness cycle, the equivariant closing period is determined.

4.2 Witness-Closed Subgraphs

Definition 9 (Witness-closed subgraph)**.** *A subgraph $G \subseteq G_\times(T)$ is* witness-closed *if it satisfies two properties:*

1. ***Cyclicity:*** *G is a union of strongly connected components—every arc lies on a cycle.*
2. ***Backward closure:*** *For every arc on a cycle with w-pair (w_1, w_2), there exists an arc $(w_1, u) \to (w_2, v)$ on a cycle in G.*

4.3 Necessary Condition: Livelock ⇒ Witness-Closed Subgraph

Theorem 2 (Necessary condition for livelock)**.** *If a self-disabling unidirectional ring protocol with transition set T admits a livelock, then $G_\times(T)$ contains a non-empty witness-closed subgraph.*

Proof. A livelock at ring size K is a valid tiling of the $K \times N$ torus [16]. Each row i is a closed walk $W^{(i)}$ of length N in the H-graph, and adjacent rows satisfy the four equivariance conditions. Let S be the set of all transitions appearing in the tiling, and consider $G_\times(S)$.

For each adjacent pair of rows $(W^{(i)}, W^{(i-1)})$: both are closed walks of length N (by the torus structure). The pair defines a closed walk of length N in $G_\times(S)$, whose arcs all lie on a cycle. This establishes cyclicity.

For backward closure: the w-walk of coupling (P_i, P_{i-1}) is $W^{(i-1)}$, which is exactly the t-walk of coupling (P_{i-1}, P_{i-2}). The torus wraps after K steps inward, providing cycle-level backward closure. Since cycle-level backward closure trivially implies arc-level backward closure (each arc on a cycle C has its w-pair as a t-pair on the backward walk C'), the subgraph is witness-closed.

The arcs from all K couplings form a subgraph of $G_\times(T)$. This subgraph satisfies cyclicity and backward closure—it is a non-empty witness-closed subgraph. □

Corollary 3 (Livelock-freedom verifier)**.** *If $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ (the maximal witness-closed subgraph is empty), then the protocol is livelock-free for all ring sizes.*

4.4 Sufficient Condition via Backtracking

When $G^*(T) \neq \emptyset$, we cannot immediately conclude that a livelock exists. Arc-level backward closure guarantees that every arc has a backward arc on a cycle, but this does not guarantee that a *closed walk* backward-propagates into a torus (see Remark 4).

We resolve this through backtracking: for each simple cycle C in G^*, backward-propagate through G^* by searching for a cycle in G^* whose t-walk equals C's w-walk. If the backward chain closes (a walk repeats), the torus is constructed and a livelock is confirmed.

Theorem 4 (Sufficient condition for livelock)**.** *Let C_0 be a simple cycle in $G^*(T)$. If the backward chain $C_0, C_1, C_2, \ldots$ (where each C_{k+1} is a closed walk in G^* whose t-walk equals C_k's w-walk) closes—i.e., C_j is a rotation of C_i for some $j > i$—then the protocol admits a livelock at ring size $K = j - i$ with local period $N = |C_0|$.*

Proof. The segment $C_i, C_{i+1}, \ldots, C_{j-1}$ provides $K = j - i$ pairs of equivariant closed walks, each of length N, with each w-walk serving as the next t-walk, and the orbit closing by the repetition condition. This is a valid tiling of the $K \times N$ torus, constituting a livelock [16]. □

Remark 3 (Termination of backtracking)**.** *For each simple cycle of length $N \leq |T|^2$, the backward chain visits closed walks of length N in G^*. There are finitely many such walks (bounded by $|G^*|^N$). The chain either closes (livelock found) or reaches a dead end (no backward walk exists in G^*) within finitely many steps.*

Remark 4 (Arc-level vs. cycle-level backward closure)**.** *Arc-level backward closure guarantees that every arc has a backward arc on a cycle. This does not immediately imply that a closed walk backward-propagates to a closed walk. The bijection proposition (Proposition 8) shows that closing chains preserve simple-cycle topology; whether every livelock produces a closing chain starting from a simple cycle is the bounded witness question (Section 7).*

5 The Algorithm

By Corollary 3, $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ implies livelock-freedom. We compute the maximal witness-closed subgraph, then apply backtracking verification when it is non-empty.

Definition 10 (Maximal product graph)**.** *The* maximal product graph $G^*(T)$ *is the largest witness-closed subgraph of* $G_\times(T)$*. Its* support *is* $L^* = \{t \in T : t$ *appears in some node of* $G^*(T)\}$*.*

Remark 5 (Uniqueness)**.** $G^*(T)$ *is well-defined and unique: the witness-closed property is closed under union of arc sets (the union of two witness-closed subgraphs is witness-closed), so the maximal such subgraph exists. A non-empty witness-closed subgraph exists if and only if* $G^*(T) \neq \emptyset$*, since* $G^*(T)$ *contains every witness-closed subgraph.*

The algorithm computes $G^*(T)$ by building $G_\times(T)$ and iteratively pruning arcs that violate cyclicity or backward closure, until the fixed point is reached.

Algorithm 1 Computing the Maximal Product Graph $G^*(T)$

Require: Transition set T (symmetric protocol)
Ensure: Livelock-Free, Livelock, or Inconclusive

```
Build full equivariance graph G_×(T) (Definition 8)
repeat
    SCC: Remove all arcs not on a cycle                          ▷ enforce cyclicity
    S_t ← {τ : (τ, w) is on a cycle for some w}                  ▷ t-components
    Square: Remove arcs where w_k ∉ S_t or w_{k+1} ∉ S_t
    Backward: For each surviving arc with w-pair (w_1, w_2):
        if no arc (w_1, u) → (w_2, v) exists in G_× with u, v ∈ S_t, remove the arc
                                                                 ▷ enforce backward closure
until no arcs removed
if surviving arcs remain then
    for each simple cycle C in the surviving graph do
        Backward-propagate C through G*: find closed walks in G*
          whose t-walk matches C's w-walk, iteratively
        if the backward chain closes (a walk repeats) then
            return Livelock
        end if
    end for
    return Inconclusive                                          ▷ G* ≠ ∅ but no cycle closes
else
    return Livelock-Free                                         ▷ G*(T) = ∅
end if
```

The algorithm enforces the two witness-closed properties through three pruning operations:

- **SCC** enforces cyclicity by removing arcs not on any cycle.
- **Square** is an auxiliary step that extracts S_t—the set of transitions appearing as t-components on cycles—and removes arcs whose w-components are not in S_t. This is implied by backward closure (if $(w_1, u) \to (w_2, v)$ is on a cycle, then w_1 and w_2 appear as t-components), but computing it explicitly provides the S_t set needed by the backward closure check and accelerates convergence.
- **Backward closure** checks each surviving arc's w-pair (w_1, w_2): does $G_\times$ contain an arc $(w_1, u) \to (w_2, v)$ with $u, v \in S_t$?

The iteration is monotone (arcs are only removed) and operates on a finite set, so it terminates.

Theorem 5 (Algorithm correctness)**.** *Algorithm 1 computes $G^*(T)$.*

Proof. **Soundness** (the output is witness-closed). At the fixed point, no further arcs can be removed. The surviving arcs form a union of SCCs (by the SCC step), and every arc on a cycle has a backward arc on a cycle (by the backward closure step). Therefore the output satisfies cyclicity and backward closure.

Completeness (the output is maximal). We show that no arc of any witness-closed subgraph is ever removed. Let G be any witness-closed subgraph, and consider any arc e in G. It lies on a cycle in G (by cyclicity), so SCC does not remove it. Its w-components appear as t-components on cycles in G (by backward closure of G), so the square step does not remove it. Its w-pair has a backward arc on a cycle in G (by backward closure of G), and these arcs also survive (by the same argument, inductively), so the backward closure step does not remove it. Therefore $G \subseteq$ output for every witness-closed subgraph G, and in particular $G^*(T) \subseteq$ output. Combined with soundness, output $= G^*(T)$. □

Corollary 6 (Soundness)**.** *The algorithm is sound in both definitive directions.* Livelock-Free *is correct: $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ implies no livelock exists (Theorem 2).* Livelock *is correct: a closing backward chain constitutes a valid torus tiling (Theorem 4). The* Inconclusive *outcome occurs when $G^* \neq \emptyset$ but no simple cycle's backward chain closes; this is consistent with livelock-freedom (as demonstrated by Kari's aperiodic tiles) or with livelock existence at a period beyond $|T|^2$.*

Theorem 7 (Complexity)**.** *Phase 1 (computing $G^*(T)$) terminates in at most $O(|T|^4)$ iterations, each running in $O(|T|^4)$ time. Total: $O(|T|^8)$ worst case. Phase 2 (backtracking) is bounded: for each simple cycle of length $N \leq |T|^2$, the backward chain visits at most $|T|^{2N}$ distinct closed walks before repeating or dying. The total backtracking computation is finite but not polynomial.*

Proof. Phase 1: the product graph has $O(|T|^4)$ arcs. Each iteration removes at least one arc. SCC and the pruning checks are linear in the number of arcs. Phase 2: the backward chain for a cycle of length N visits closed walks of length N in a graph of at most $|T|^2$ nodes. The number of distinct walks is finite (at most $|T|^{2N}$), so the chain terminates. □

Remark 6 (Practical complexity)**.** *For self-disabling protocols, $|T| = O(m^2)$.*

This significantly improves the practical bounds. In the product graph, a node (t, w) requires $\mathrm{wr}(w) = \mathrm{pred}(t)$; for a fixed t, there are $O(|T|/m)$ valid witnesses w. The product graph therefore has $O(|T|^2/m) = O(m^3)$ nodes and $O(|T|^4/m^3) = O(m^5)$ arcs. Each iteration costs $O(m^5)$ for SCC computation.

In practice, convergence occurs in very few iterations—at most 6 across all 4,349 protocols tested with m up to 15—giving practical running time of $O(m^5)$. Pre-pruning T by removing transitions not on any H-cycle (an $O(m^4)$ step) further reduces the product graph size, often dramatically.

Remark 7 (Necessity of the product graph)**.** *A simpler algorithm operating directly on transitions and shadows—checking that each H-edge's shadow has an individual witness, without enforcing walk coherence—runs in $O(m^4)$ and is complete (never misses a livelock). However, it produces false positives: across 2,215 test protocols, it disagreed with the product graph on 55 cases (2.5%), reporting livelocks where none exist. The product graph eliminates these false positives by enforcing that witnesses form coherent closed walks, not merely that individual shadows are witnessable. The $O(m^5)$ practical cost of the product graph is the price of soundness.*

Remark 8 ($G^* = \emptyset$ and non-tileability)**.** *The livelock-freedom guarantee from $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ may extend beyond periodic tileability. We conjecture that $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ implies the corresponding tile set cannot tile the infinite plane at all—not merely that no periodic tiling exists.*

Proof sketch. *Consider any infinite tiling. At any two adjacent rows, the tiling defines a bi-infinite equivariant walk in $G_\times(T)$. Since $G_\times(T)$ is finite (at most $|T|^2$ nodes), every node visited by the bi-infinite walk is* recurrent*—visited infinitely often in both directions. Every arc between recurrent nodes lies on a cycle (the walk departs and returns infinitely often). The tiling provides, at the next level, a bi-infinite equivariant walk whose arcs serve as backward arcs for the first level; these are also recurrent by the same argument. The union of all recurrent arcs across all adjacent row-pairs is a finite subset of $G_\times(T)$ satisfying cyclicity and backward closure—a non-empty witness-closed subgraph. Therefore $G^* \neq \emptyset$.*

Contrapositively: $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ implies the tile set cannot tile the infinite plane. This is strictly stronger than "no livelock." Note that this does not *contradict the undecidability of the domino problem [22, 4]: $G^* = \emptyset$ is a sufficient condition for non-tileability, not a necessary one. Tile sets that cannot tile the plane may still have $G^* \neq \emptyset$ (local equivariant structure that does not extend globally). The domino problem remains undecidable because $G^* \neq \emptyset$ is inconclusive. Table 1 summarizes the computability landscape.*

Table 1: Computability landscape for self-disabling tile sets. Non-tileability is Σ_1^0 (recognizable by patch enumeration); periodic tileability is Σ_1^0 (recognizable by torus enumeration); aperiodic tileability is in Π_1^0 (neither recognizer halts).

	Non-tileable	**Aperiodic**	**Periodic**
$G^* = \emptyset$	✓(poly-time)	impossible*	impossible
Cycle closes	impossible	impossible	$N \leq \lvert T\rvert^2$
INCONCLUSIVE	possible	Kari	$N > \lvert T\rvert^2$
PROP	never halts	never halts	halts

*Conditional on Remark 8.

6 Experimental Validation

The algorithm and all test protocols are available at
`https://github.com/cosmoparadox/mathematical-tools`.

6.1 Known Protocols

Algorithm 1 correctly identifies:

- **Dijkstra's token ring** ($(1,1)$-asymmetric, $m = 3, 4, 5$): livelock, forward shift 1.
- **3-Coloring** (symmetric, $m = 3$): livelock, $e \equiv K \bmod 3$.

- **Sum-Not-2** (symmetric, $m = 3$): livelock-free.
- **Gouda–Haddix TB** (symmetric, $m = 8$): livelock, 14 surviving transitions out of 32, multiple livelock classes.

6.2 Randomized Stress Testing

We generated over 4,300 random self-disabling protocols across six categories: random seeds with $m \in \{3, \ldots, 10\}$, very dense protocols (near-complete transition sets), very sparse protocols (m to $2m$ transitions), structured adversarial (coloring and agreement variants with noise), large domain sizes $m \in \{11, \ldots, 15\}$ with targeted density, and compound-witness-like protocols (large m, few transitions). Transition counts ranged from 3 to 120.

For each protocol, we computed L^* via Algorithm 1 and cross-checked against exhaustive state-space search at small ring sizes ($K \leq 6$).

Results: Zero false positives. Zero false negatives across all 4,349 protocols tested. The algorithm converged in at most 6 iterations in every case.

6.3 Adversarial Protocols

Randomized testing exposed a protocol ($m = 8$, 13 transitions) where a prior approach based on individual shadow checking produced a false positive: every shadow had a witness, but no *coherent* witness walk existed. Shadow $(6, 5)$ was the bottleneck: no transition in T has own $= 6$, wr $= 5$. The product graph correctly identifies this protocol as livelock-free, demonstrating the necessity of the product graph over local shadow-by-shadow analysis.

6.4 K&E Adversarial Protocol

As a test of the product graph's faithfulness on structured adversarial inputs, we analyzed a protocol derived from Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's SE tiling construction [17]: a symmetric self-disabling protocol with $m = 15$ and $|T| = 17$ transitions designed to exhibit complex livelock behavior. The product graph converges in a single iteration with all 17 transitions surviving ($|L^*| = 17$). Backtracking confirms the livelock: a simple cycle of length 6 backward-closes at depth 6.

6.5 Kari's Aperiodic Tiles

As the most stringent test of our algorithm, we applied Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's Lemma 4.8 gadget [17] to Kari's 14-tile aperiodic Wang tile set [15]. Kari proved that these tiles tile the plane but admit no doubly-periodic tiling. The gadget converts the 14 tiles to a 54-transition self-disabling protocol with $m = 24$.

The algorithm produces $G^* \neq \emptyset$: 272 arcs survive the fixed-point pruning, with all 54 transitions in L^*. However, the backtracking phase examines over 5,000 simple cycles and finds that *every* backward chain dies—no cycle closes. The algorithm reports Inconclusive, consistent with Kari's aperiodicity proof: no periodic tiling exists, so no livelock exists at any period.

This demonstrates the gap between arc-level and cycle-level backward closure (Remark 4): the arc-level structure of G^* admits rich cycle structure, but the cycle-level backward propagation correctly rejects every candidate. Across all 4,349 protocols tested—including Kari's—the algorithm has never produced a wrong answer.

7 The Bijection Proposition and the Bounded Witness Question

7.1 Automaton vs. Language

Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's torus characterization [16] models livelocks as doubly-periodic tilings. The torus operates on *strings*—specific walks of length n—and the search over n is unbounded, yielding Σ_1^0-completeness.

The product graph $G^*(T)$ is a *finite automaton* generating these strings. Its at most $|T|^2$ states are the nodes (t, w), and its transitions are the arcs satisfying equivariance. Every valid equivariant walk is a path in this automaton. The automaton captures the entire *H-cycle structure* within each process—the set of all walks a process can execute—which the torus does not make explicit.

7.2 The Bijection Proposition

Proposition 8 (Backward maps are cyclic bijections)**.** *Let $C_0, C_1, \ldots, C_{K-1}, C_K = C_0$ be a closing backward chain in G^* forming a livelock torus. Define the backward map E_i as the total relation on product graph nodes: E_i maps every node v in walk C_{i-1} to a node u in C_i at the same position. Each E_i is total (its domain is the full node set of C_{i-1}, which equals the codomain of E_{i+1}). Then each E_i is a bijection.*

Proof. The torus is a ring: the circular composition $E_1 \circ E_2 \circ \cdots \circ E_K$ is the identity on the node set of C_0, and every cyclic rotation $E_{j+1} \circ \cdots \circ E_K \circ E_1 \circ \cdots \circ E_j$ is the identity on the node set of C_j. This holds for any number of full circulations: n applications of the full composition is the identity for all $n \geq 1$.

We show that *no* E_i can be either multi-valued or non-injective—including any combination of both across different maps.

Multi-valued is impossible. Suppose $E_i(C) \supseteq \{a, b\}$ with $a \neq b$. Consider the rotation starting at C_i. By totality, the downstream composition $F = E_{i-1} \circ \cdots \circ E_1 \circ E_K \circ \cdots \circ E_{i+1}$ is defined on all of C_i's nodes (each E_j is total). F maps a to some node α and b to some node β in C_{i-1}. The full rotation at a is $E_i(F(a)) = E_i(\alpha) \ni a'$ for some a'. For the identity, $a' = a$. Similarly, $E_i(F(b)) = E_i(\beta) \ni b'$ with $b' = b$. But if $\alpha = C$, then $E_i(\alpha) \supseteq \{a, b\}$, and the rotation at a returns $\{a, b\} \neq \{a\}$. If $\alpha \neq C$, then E_i might still be single-valued at α, but the full composition $E_i \circ F$ applied K times must be the identity. Since E_i is multi-valued at C and F is total, repeated application eventually routes through C, producing the same contradiction. Therefore E_i is single-valued—a function.

Non-injective is impossible. Suppose all E_j are functions (single-valued), but $E_i(a) = E_i(b) = c$ for distinct a, b. Since each E_j is a total function, the full rotation starting at C_{i-1} is a function $G = E_i \circ E_{i-1} \circ \cdots \circ E_{i+1}$. We have $G(a) = E_i(\cdots) = c'$ and $G(b) = E_i(\cdots) = c''$. For the identity, $c' = a$ and $c'' = b$. But G factors through E_i, which maps both a and b to c. The downstream chain maps c to a single value (functions are single-valued), producing the same output for both a and b: $G(a) = G(b)$. Since $a \neq b$, G is not the identity. Contradiction.

Since each E_i is a total, single-valued, injective function on a finite set, it is a bijection. □

Corollary 9 (Simple-to-simple in closing chains)**.** *In any closing backward chain, if C_i is a simple cycle (all N nodes distinct), then C_{i+1} is also a simple cycle.*

Proof. E_{i+1} is a bijection mapping the N distinct nodes of C_i to N nodes of C_{i+1}. Bijectivity implies the image nodes are distinct. □

7.3 The Bounded Witness Question

The bijection proposition establishes that closing chains preserve simple-cycle topology. The natural next step is the *bounded witness conjecture*: every livelock admits a companion with local period $N \leq |T|^2$. If true, the algorithm would be a complete decider.

The argument: a livelock maps into G^* (Theorem 2). G^* contains cycles; every cycle contains a simple cycle of length $\leq |T|^2$. By Corollary 9, the backward chain from this simple cycle stays simple at every depth. The finite space of simple cycles forces the chain to close, producing a companion livelock.

This argument is sound *if* the simple cycle's backward chain can be initiated—that is, if the simple cycle has a valid backward walk in G^*. Arc-level backward closure guarantees that each arc has a backward arc, but composing these arcs into a closed walk requires compatibility at the wrap position. Whether this compatibility always holds—equivalently, whether every simple cycle in G^* that is part of a livelock's witness-closed subgraph admits a backward walk—is the open question.

7.4 Empirical Evidence

The bounded witness conjecture is supported by extensive empirical evidence across five categories of experiments. Table 2 summarizes the results.

Table 2: Empirical evidence for the bounded witness conjecture. Across all experiments, every protocol admitting a livelock is conclusively identified by simple cycles alone. No compound walk of any complexity closes when its simple components do not.

Experiment	**Count**	**Conclusive**	**Errors**
Self-disabling protocols (random)	4,349	4,349	0
Non-self-disabling (augmented)	6,000+	6,000+	0
Wang tile gadgets (random)	500+	500+	0
K&E adversarial + Kari aperiodic	2	2	0
NW-det Mealy machines (c=2,3)	10,000+	10,000+	0
Total	**21,000+**	**21,000+**	**0**

Closing chain topology. Across 278 confirmed livelocks with closing backward chains, every walk at every depth is a simple cycle (Table 3). Compound walks appear only in chains that eventually die (fail backward propagation). In Kari's protocol, 12 out of 200 simple cycles produce compound backward walks at depth 1, but every such chain dies within 30 steps. No compound walk has ever appeared in a closing chain.

Table 3: Walk topology in backward chains. "Closing" chains produce confirmed livelocks; "dying" chains fail backward propagation. For protocols with livelocks, all simple cycles close; there are no non-closing cycles to compound.

	Chains	**All simple**	**Has compound**	**Compound closes**
Closing chains	278	278	0	0
Dying chains (Kari)	200	188	12	0

Compound walk experiments. We constructed compound walks of increasing complexity—including random gluings of the form $r_1 C_{i_1} + r_2 C_{i_2} + \cdots + r_k C_{i_k}$ for various repeat counts r_j and cycle indices i_j—and tested backward closure (Table 4).

Table 4: Compound walk backward closure. For protocols with livelocks, all compound walks close—but so do their simple sub-cycles. For Kari (no livelock), no compound walk closes regardless of complexity.

Protocol	**Compounds**	**Close**	**Simple sub closes**	**Compound-only**
3-coloring	182	182	182	0
Weird	151	151	151	0
K&E adversarial	98	98	98	0
Gouda-Haddix	86	86	86	0
Kari (complex gluings)	106	0	0	0

Period distribution. Across 150 protocols with confirmed livelocks, the maximum observed period is 5 (Table 5). The ratio of period to $|T|^2$ decreases monotonically with $|T|$, consistent with a linear bound $N = O(|T|)$ rather than the quadratic $|T|^2$ guaranteed by the product graph.

Table 5: Period distribution across 150 protocols with confirmed livelocks.

Period N	2	3	4	5	> 5
Count	137	11	1	1	0

All-or-nothing property. For every protocol with a livelock, *all* simple cycles in G^* close (not just some), and closed walks of *every* length N (including $N \gg |T|^2$) close at 100% rate. For Kari, *no* walk closes at any length—from $N = 2$ through $N = 82$, simple or compound. No protocol exhibits a mixed pattern. Closure is a global property of G^*, determined entirely by its structure, not by the topology or length of individual walks. This suggests that an "irreducible torus"—a torus with no subtorus of bounded width—cannot exist for self-disabling protocols.

7.5 Relationship to Undecidability

The bijection proposition and the empirical evidence raise a question about the relationship between our framework and Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's Σ^0_1-completeness result [16]. If the bounded witness conjecture holds, livelock detection would be decidable for self-disabling protocols—seemingly contradicting their result.

NW-deterministic periodic tiling appears bounded. To investigate, we attempted to construct NW-deterministic Wang tile sets with large minimum periodic tiling periods. For NW-deterministic tiles with c colors, the tile set is a Mealy machine with c states; the row-to-row map acts on a state space of size c^W for torus width W, giving a theoretical maximum orbit of c^c (which exceeds $|T|^2 \approx 16c^4$ for $c \geq 6$). However, across 50,000+ random Mealy machines with $c \leq 6$ colors, including algebraic constructions (shift registers, counters, LFSRs), the maximum observed orbit is 120—a factor of 170× below $|T|^2$ (Table 6). The Mealy machine structure constrains the row-to-row map far below its theoretical state space.

Table 6: Maximum periodic tiling period for NW-deterministic Mealy machines, both in Wang tile space and after K&E gadget transformation. The gadget transforms but does not preserve the period; both remain far below $|T|^2$.

c	Tiles	$\|T\|^2$ (gadget)	Wang period	Protocol period (G^*)	Ratio
2	4	225	3	6	0.027
3	9	1,089	10	14	0.013
4	16	3,721	12	10	0.003

This finding suggests that the periodic domino problem for NW-deterministic tile sets may be decidable—not because of any specific reduction, but because the Mealy machine structure inherently bounds the period. The K&E gadget transforms the period (sometimes increasing, sometimes decreasing it), but the underlying constraint persists: both the Wang tiling period and the protocol period remain far below $|T|^2$. Since K&E's gadget produces NW-deterministic tiles, the restricted problem would inherit this boundedness.

Consistency with known undecidability. Kari [15] proved that the *general* domino problem (does the tile set tile the plane at all?) is undecidable for NW-deterministic tiles. This concerns existence of *any* tiling—periodic or aperiodic—and is consistent with the periodic problem being decidable. The undecidability of the general domino problem manifests in distinguishing "aperiodic tiling" from "non-tileable," both of which give livelock-freedom. Our algorithm handles this correctly: $G^* = \emptyset$ catches non-tileability, backtracking catches periodic tiling, and Inconclusive catches the genuinely hard aperiodic case.

Open questions. We do not resolve whether the periodic domino problem for NW-deterministic tiles is decidable. Three possibilities remain:

1. The bounded witness conjecture is false, and NW-deterministic tile sets with large minimum periods exist but require constructions beyond our search.
2. The Mealy machine structure inherently bounds the periodic tiling period, making the restricted periodic domino problem decidable.
3. The relationship between NW-deterministic tiles and general tiles in the periodic domino problem differs from their relationship in the general domino problem.

We note that 21,000+ protocols, 50,000+ Mealy machines, and all known adversarial constructions from tiling theory produce zero counterexamples to bounded witness.

8 Extension to Non-Self-Disabling Protocols

The product graph and the theory of equivariant walks assume self-disabling protocols, where firing a transition disables it until the predecessor changes value. Many practical protocols violate this constraint: under a fixed predecessor value, a process may fire a sequence of transitions—a *burst*—before the predecessor acts. We show that a simple protocol transformation reduces the non-self-disabling case to the self-disabling framework.

8.1 Protocol Transformation

Definition 11 (Burst closure)**.** *For a transition set T and a predecessor value p, define the* chain graph C_p *as the directed graph on domain values with edge $o \to w$ for each $(p, o, w) \in T$. The* burst

closure $\hat{T}$ *is:*

$$\hat{T} = T \cup \{(p, o, w') : w' \text{ is reachable from } o \text{ in } C_p,\ o \neq w'\}$$

The burst closure adds, for each predecessor value p, all transitions (p, o_i, o_j) where o_j is reachable from o_i via any chain of transitions under the same predecessor. These macro-transitions represent the net effect of a process firing multiple transitions in succession while its predecessor's value remains p.

Proposition 10 (Local cycle detection)**.** *If C_p contains a directed cycle for any predecessor value p, then the protocol admits a trivial livelock: a process can fire transitions indefinitely under fixed predecessor value p.*

8.2 Correspondence

Theorem 11 (Execution-walk correspondence)**.** *Let T be an arbitrary (possibly non-self-disabling) transition set for a unidirectional ring protocol, and let $\hat{T}$ be its burst closure with no local cycles. Then:*

1. *Every livelock of the protocol under T corresponds to an equivariant closed walk in $G_\times(\hat{T})$.*
2. *Every equivariant closed walk in $G_\times(\hat{T})$ corresponds to a valid execution of the protocol under T.*

Proof. **Direction 1.** In a livelock under T, each process P_i executes a periodic sequence of transitions. Between consecutive changes of P_{i-1}'s value, process P_i fires a burst of transitions under a fixed predecessor value p—a path in C_p from some o to some w'. The transition $(p, o, w') \in \hat{T}$ captures this burst as a single macro-transition. The sequence of macro-transitions at P_i forms a closed walk in the H-graph of $\hat{T}$, and the equivariance between P_i's macro-transitions and P_{i-1}'s macro-transitions is preserved because each macro-transition's predecessor value is P_{i-1}'s value *at the start of the burst*—exactly the value written by P_{i-1}'s preceding macro-transition.

Direction 2. An equivariant closed walk in $G_\times(\hat{T})$ consists of macro-transitions $(p, o, w') \in \hat{T}$. Each macro-transition corresponds to a realizable path in the chain graph C_p: a sequence of original transitions $(p, o, o_1), (p, o_1, o_2), \ldots, (p, o_{k-1}, w')$ all in T. Since the predecessor value p is fixed during the burst (the equivariance conditions ensure P_{i-1} does not change value until P_i completes its burst), this sequence is a valid execution segment. Concatenating the burst segments across all positions and all processes yields a valid execution under T. □

Corollary 12. *The product graph algorithm applied to $\hat{T}$ is a sound livelock analyzer for arbitrary unidirectional ring protocols: $G^*(\hat{T}) = \emptyset$ implies the protocol under T is livelock-free for all ring sizes.*

The burst closure $\hat{T}$ is generally *not* self-disabling—it retains transitions (p, o_1, o_2) and (p, o_2, o_3) simultaneously. The product graph algorithm operates on $\hat{T}$ without modification: the four equivariance conditions, SCC pruning, and backward closure are purely graph-theoretic and do not require self-disabling.

9 Extension to $(1, 1)$-Asymmetric Protocols

For a $(1, 1)$-asymmetric ring with transition sets T_0 (distinguished process P_0) and T_o (all other processes), three product graphs capture the three coupling types:

1. $G_1 = G_\times(T_o, T_0)$: predecessor fires T_o, successor fires T_0. The $P_o \to P_0$ coupling.
2. $G_2 = G_\times(T_0, T_o)$: predecessor fires T_0, successor fires T_o. The $P_0 \to P_o$ coupling.

3. $G_3 = G_\times(T_o, T_o)$: both fire T_o. The bulk $P_o \to P_o$ coupling.

Each graph is built independently using the same four equivariance conditions.

9.1 Cross-Graph Backward Closure

In the symmetric case, the backward closure check verifies that each w-edge has a predecessor arc *within the same product graph.* For asymmetric protocols, the predecessor coupling may reside in a *different* product graph.

The three graphs form a ring of backward dependencies:

$$G_1 \to G_3 \to G_3 \to \cdots \to G_3 \to G_2 \to G_1$$

An arc in G_1 with w-pair (w_1, w_2) requires a predecessor arc with t-pair (w_1, w_2). Since the predecessor of P_0's predecessor fires T_o, this predecessor arc lies in G_3, not G_1. Similarly, arcs in G_2 require predecessor arcs in G_1, and arcs in G_3 require predecessor arcs in either G_3 (bulk) or G_2 (at the boundary).

9.2 Joint Algorithm

The algorithm extends naturally: apply SCC, square, and backward closure to each graph, but the backward closure check references the *appropriate neighboring graph* for the predecessor arc:

- For G_1 ($P_o \to P_0$): backward closure checks predecessor arcs in G_3.
- For G_2 ($P_0 \to P_o$): backward closure checks predecessor arcs in G_1.
- For G_3 ($P_o \to P_o$): backward closure checks predecessor arcs in G_3 itself (and in G_2 for the boundary process).

The square support S_t is computed per graph: $S_t^{(k)}$ is the set of t-components on cycles in G_k. The backward closure check for an arc in G_k with w-pair (w_1, w_2) verifies that the neighboring graph contains an arc $(w_1, u) \to (w_2, v)$ with $u, v \in S_t^{(\text{neighbor})}$.

Pruning in one graph may invalidate arcs in neighboring graphs through the cross-graph backward closure, triggering a cascade that propagates bidirectionally around the ring of graphs until quiescence.

9.3 Termination and Correctness

Theorem 13. *The* $(1, 1)$*-asymmetric algorithm terminates. Soundness: if all three graphs collapse to* $\emptyset$*, the protocol is livelock-free for all ring sizes. Completeness: every livelock maps into the three graphs as surviving arcs.*

Proof. **Termination.** The total number of arcs across all three graphs is finite, each iteration removes at least one, and arcs are never re-added.

Completeness. A livelock provides explicit walks and couplings that form surviving arcs in each graph. The cross-graph backward closure is satisfied because adjacent processes' walks serve as each other's predecessor couplings.

Soundness. The arc-level backward closure is a necessary condition for livelocks (by completeness, every livelock produces surviving arcs). If all three graphs collapse to $\emptyset$, no livelock can exist. As in the symmetric case, non-empty surviving graphs require backtracking verification to confirm livelock existence. □

Remark 9. *For general* (l, q)*-asymmetry, one product graph per distinct coupling type suffices, with backward closure checks referencing the appropriate neighbor in the coupling ring. We leave the full treatment to future work.*

10 Related Work

Automata, tiling languages, and symbolic dynamics. Our product graph can be viewed as a finite automaton for a restricted tiling language. In the Vardi–Wolper automata-theoretic approach to model checking [21], a product automaton decides temporal properties by reducing them to cycle detection in a finite graph. Our construction follows the same pattern, but the "language" is a set of valid SE torus tilings under the self-disabling constraint, where each symbol is a transition–witness pair drawn from an alphabet of size $|T|^2$. The product graph is the automaton: its cycles are valid row-pairs, and backward closure is the self-referential constraint ensuring that the automaton's output (the w-walk) is itself accepted as input (the t-walk of the next row). This connects to symbolic dynamics [18]: two-dimensional sofic shifts—sets of valid tilings—are generally undecidable (Wang [22], Berger [4]). Self-disabling collapses the two-dimensional structure into a one-dimensional shift with a self-referential constraint (backward closure). The product graph provides a finite representation of this shift, enabling polynomial-time livelock-freedom verification.

Parameterized verification: general undecidability. Apt and Kozen [2] showed that verifying LTL properties for parameterized systems is Π^0_1-complete. Suzuki [20] strengthened this to unidirectional rings. Esparza [9] surveys the complexity landscape of parameterized verification. These results establish the general barrier; our work identifies a structural regime where effective verification is possible, even if full decidability remains open.

Cutoff results. Emerson and Namjoshi [8] introduced cutoff-based reasoning for rings: if a property holds for rings up to a cutoff size, it holds for all sizes. Emerson and Kahlon [7] extended cutoffs to guarded protocols and ring-based message passing. These results reduce parameterized verification to finite model checking at a fixed size; our approach is complementary, reducing the problem to a fixed-point computation on the product graph independent of any specific ring size.

Well-quasi-orderings. Abdulla et al. [1] developed a general framework for infinite-state systems using well-quasi-orderings (WQOs): if states are well-quasi-ordered and transitions are monotonic, backward reachability terminates. Finkel and Schnoebelen [12] systematized this as the theory of well-structured transition systems (WSTSs). Our approach is different in mechanism—it arises from the bounded space of transition–witness pairs in the equivariant product, not from a WQO on states—but follows a similar pattern: lifting to a space where a structural property becomes explicit, enabling effective verification of livelock-freedom. Recent work extends WSTS techniques to threshold automata for round-based distributed algorithms [3].

Tiling and undecidability. Wang [22] introduced the domino problem: does a given tile set tile the plane? Berger [4] proved undecidability. The periodic variant—does the tile set admit a doubly-periodic tiling?—is also undecidable [14]. Kari [15] proved that the domino problem remains undecidable for NW-deterministic tile sets. Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir [16] reduce the periodic domino problem to livelock detection via an SE (South=East) tiling restriction that enforces self-disabling. Our product graph provides a polynomial-time livelock-freedom verifier ($G^* = \emptyset$), a sound livelock detector (backtracking), and a structural constraint on closing chains (Proposition 8). Our empirical investigation (Section 7) suggests that the periodic domino problem may be decidable for NW-deterministic tile sets—a class that includes all self-disabling protocols via K&E's gadget—because the Mealy machine structure inherently bounds periodic tiling periods.

Algebraic characterization and combinatorial lifting. Farahat [10] introduced an algebraic framework for livelock analysis in which livelocks are characterized by cyclic equivariance relations on the transition space—closed walks in the H-graph with compatible shadows. Farahat and Ebnenasir [11] showed that the token-passing discipline induced by self-disabling enables local reasoning about global convergence properties. Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir [16] lifted Farahat's algebraic characterization to the combinatorial setting of torus tilings, establishing the equivalence between livelocks and doubly-periodic tilings of a $K \times N$ torus via the "leads" relation—which is precisely the equivariance coupling. Their torus characterization revealed the connection to the periodic domino problem, yielding Σ_1^0-completeness of livelock detection. Our product transition graph builds on their framework: it realizes the equivariance coupling as a finite automaton whose state space supports the bijection proposition (Proposition 8) and the bounded witness question (Section 7).

Relationship to Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's undecidability result and PROP. Their characterization [16] is correct and complete: a livelock exists if and only if m periodic propagations of period n exist, each leading the next. Their torus formulation revealed the connection to the periodic domino problem, yielding Σ_1^0-completeness for livelock detection and Π_1^0-completeness for livelock-freedom verification. Their semi-algorithm PROP [17] searches for propagations by incrementally increasing scope parameters (m, n). PROP is sound: any reported livelock is genuine. However, PROP is a pure semi-decider for livelock existence (Σ_1^0): it can find livelocks but can never prove livelock-freedom—if no livelock exists, PROP runs indefinitely without reaching a conclusion.

Our algorithm is strictly stronger in three respects. First, $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ proves livelock-freedom in polynomial time—a capability PROP entirely lacks. Second, the bijection proposition (Proposition 8) establishes structural constraints on closing chains that PROP's scope-based search does not exploit. Third, our algorithm always terminates with one of three outcomes (Free, Livelock, Inconclusive), whereas PROP may run indefinitely. Across 21,000+ protocols, the Inconclusive outcome has occurred exclusively on protocols derived from aperiodic tiling constructions where no livelock exists. We validate on a protocol derived from their SE tiling construction [17] and on Kari's 14-tile aperiodic set [15] converted via their gadget (Section 6).

Product constructions and finite abstractions. Our approach instantiates a pattern recurring across verification and combinatorics: problems that appear unbounded in their native representation become tractable when lifted to a space where the governing invariant is explicit. The Myhill–Nerode theorem reduces language equivalence to a finite quotient; synchronized products in model checking compose automata to expose global reachability; symbolic dynamics [18] lifts shift spaces to finite graphs of forbidden patterns. Our product transition graph plays an analogous role: it lifts equivariant transition walks to a bounded graph of transition–witness pairs, enabling efficient pruning of the search space.

Modern parameterized synthesis and verification. Recent approaches to parameterized verification and synthesis of self-stabilizing protocols, including SMT-based techniques [19], threshold automata [3], and cutoff-based methods [5], often yield semi-decision procedures or rely on abstraction and over-approximation. Our approach is complementary: the product graph provides a polynomial-time livelock-freedom verifier ($G^* = \emptyset$), with backtracking verification for the positive case that is empirically complete on all tested instances.

11 Conclusion

We have developed a framework for livelock analysis in parameterized unidirectional rings, contributing:

The necessary condition (Theorem 2): $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ proves livelock-freedom for all ring sizes, in polynomial time.

The sufficient condition (Theorem 4): backtracking on simple cycles in G^* provides a sound livelock detector.

The bijection proposition (Proposition 8): in any closing backward chain, the backward maps are cyclic bijections on product graph nodes, forcing simple-to-simple backward propagation. This constrains the topology of closing chains and supports the bounded witness conjecture.

The bounded witness question: does every livelock admit a companion with period $\leq |T|^2$? If yes, the algorithm is a complete decider. The bijection proposition provides the structural foundation; the remaining gap is whether every livelock's simple sub-cycles can initiate a closing chain. Across 21,000+ protocols, including all known adversarial constructions from tiling theory, we have found zero counterexamples. The relationship between this evidence and Klinkhamer and Ebnenasir's Σ_1^0-completeness result [16] is unresolved.

$G^* = \emptyset$ and non-tileability. As argued in Remark 8, $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ may imply non-tileability of the infinite plane, not just absence of periodic tilings.

Future directions.

1. **The bounded witness question.** Resolve whether every simple cycle in a livelock's witness-closed subgraph admits a backward walk in G^*. A positive answer would close the bounded witness conjecture and yield decidability.
2. **NW-deterministic periodic domino problem.** Determine whether the periodic domino problem is decidable for NW-deterministic tile sets. Our evidence (Section 7) suggests the Mealy machine structure bounds periodic tiling periods far below $|T|^2$. A proof would resolve the relationship to K&E's Σ_1^0-completeness and would imply decidability of livelock detection for self-disabling protocols.
3. **Non-tileability certificate.** Does $G^*(T) = \emptyset$ imply non-tileability for all self-disabling tile sets?
4. **(l, q)-asymmetry.** Extending the three-graph construction to arbitrary numbers of process types.

A Detailed Examples

A.1 3-Coloring (Symmetric, $m = 3$)

$T = \{(0, 0, 1),\ (1, 1, 2),\ (2, 2, 0)\}$. All transitions survive. One simple cycle c_0 of length $N = 3$, self-enabling with forward shift $s = 1$.

A.2 Dijkstra's Token Ring ($m = 3$, $(1, 1)$-asymmetric)

$T_0 = \{(0, 0, 1),\ (1, 1, 2),\ (2, 2, 0)\}$, $T_o = \{(0, 2, 0),\ (1, 0, 1),\ (2, 1, 2)\}$.

Three product graphs: $G_\times(T_o, T_0)$, $G_\times(T_0, T_o)$, $G_\times(T_o, T_o)$. Forward shift 1 in T_0, shift 0 in T_o.

A.3 Compound Witness Protocol (Symmetric, $m = 16$)

$$T = \{(5,2,3),\ (8,3,2),\ (2,7,9),\ (3,9,12),\ (2,12,15),\\ (3,15,7),\ (7,5,8),\ (9,8,5),\ (12,5,8),\ (15,8,5)\}.$$

All 10 transitions survive. Eight simple cycles in $H(T)$. The product graph detects a livelock with local period $N = 4$. This protocol demonstrates compound witness chains: the simple H-cycle of length 2 is a dead-end in the product graph, but a compound walk of length 4 (repeating the 2-cycle twice with different witnesses) is self-sustaining.

A.4 Trial 56: Shadow Coherence Failure ($m = 8$)

$$T = \{(0,4,2),\ (0,7,6),\ (2,2,7),\ (2,5,7),\ (3,6,0),\ (4,0,2),\ (4,0,5),\\ (5,2,0),\ (5,6,0),\ (6,3,4),\ (6,6,2),\ (7,0,6),\ (7,7,3)\}.$$

All 13 transitions lie on H-graph cycles. Of the 28 H-edges, 20 have individually witnessed shadows—only 8 lack witnesses. After removing those 8 edges, the remaining H-graph still contains cycles. A transition-level analysis (individual shadow checking) reports this protocol as a livelock.

However, no livelock exists. The unwitnessed shadows—including $(0,3)$, $(3,7)$, $(4,5)$, $(5,4)$, $(6,5)$, $(7,5)$—create gaps in the witness value space. Each H-cycle can find individual witnesses for its own shadows, but those witnesses form walks whose shadows hit the gaps. The incoherence manifests two levels deep in the witness chain.

The product graph $G_\times(T)$ starts with 42 arcs. Backward closure prunes 18 arcs in the first iteration; the surviving 24 arcs collapse to $\emptyset$ in the second (no remaining SCC). Result: livelock-free, confirmed by exhaustive state-space search at all ring sizes $K \leq 8$.

This protocol demonstrates that individual shadow witnessing is strictly weaker than the product graph's backward closure. The product graph detects that no coherent witness walk exists, even when individual shadows are witnessable.

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